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Iola Brubeck

Iola (Whitlock) Brubeck was born in 1923 in Corning, California. She met Dave Brubeck when they were both students at the College of the Pacific in Stockton, CA. They will celebrate 70 years together in 2012. Iola's contribution to Dave's career and legacy are significant and ongoing. As their oldest son, Darius, stated, "She was and is, on every level, the anchor and the organizer."

Iola was interviewed in Wilton, Connecticut on July 17, 2011, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am in the Brubeck residence in Wilton, Connecticut, and I'm very, very pleased to have Iola Brubeck with me today for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College.

IB: Oh well thank you.

MR: I have to tell you I will do a good deal of bragging to my jazz circles that I've been in the Brubeck house twice now. It's a real pleasure for me. And I wanted to congratulate you on your almost-70 years together as a couple, is that right?

IB: That's right. We were married in 1942.

MR: Can you remember if your parents were excited about you marrying a piano player?

IB: I don't think they were too aware of the hazards involved, and they liked Dave personally. And of course we were both very young. I think they were a little questioning that perhaps. But he was only 21 and I had my 19th birthday in August and we were married in September.

MR: Were you aware of the hazards of the music profession?

IB: No, I was not. I knew nothing. I knew nothing about it. However, we were talking last night about an incident when we were with some friends. And they asked about when we were first going together and dating. And Dave said on this first major date we had we went to San Francisco and we went to a club that was in the black district of San Francisco, it was called Club Alabam. I was the only white girl in the club. And he knew the musicians who were on the bandstand and they invited him to sit in, which he did, and everyone was enjoying it and the club had booths on all sides and tables in the middle. And I was sitting in a booth. And two couples were in front and one of the women looked over the booth wall and said to me, "Is that boy colored?" And I said, "No I don't think so." And she said, "He sure plays like he's colored." So that was sort of my introduction into a jazz pianist's life. Because I had no idea of what it would be like.

MR: Isn't that funny. You know he sort of had that thing follow him around. I'm sure it's well

thing. And I have to chuckle because I have a *DownBeat* here from 1957, and he responded to that question. He said something like any jackass can swing and I can too. It sounded like it got his dander up a little bit.

IB: Yes, I think because his style was different from the prevailing style of that time, it took some people a long time to kind of accept that it could be legitimate, even if it was different. And it seems to me that in the history of jazz the people who have made some kind of mark, they were different. They introduced something different.

MR: As opposed to just being a craftsman and sort of an innovator.

IB: Yes.

MR: Well we look at the career of you and Dave now and we may forget that you paid dues early on. And the book [*It's About Time*] it was talking about some of the hard times you had. And I'm a musician myself and I almost can relate to that. I say, "Oh they struggled too."

IB: Yes. I think any musician could relate to that, yeah. Yes, the early years can be very, very difficult and this is the period when I think the chaff and the wheat are separated, that some people just say it's too much to pay and I'll go do something else. I'll sell real estate, it's a lot easier. And others hang on. And I think if you're really serious about being a musician or an artist or a writer or a doctor, you have to have the desire to stay with it, no matter what knocks you get. And it takes a great commitment. And sometimes the price is pretty high.

MR: What price was that for you two back then? Did you ever have a discussion late at night when the kids were in bed? Maybe you had your sons by then. You know, this is too hard. One of us has to get a day job.

IB: Yes.

MR: Did you ever have that conversation?

IB: Well I have a very funny story about that. In San Francisco, this was before there was a trio or a quartet, and Dave was just doing casuals when he could find them. And it was very difficult to pay the rent and put food on the table and we had a conversation where Dave was laughing about in San Francisco at that time, all of the garbage men who came around sang Italian opera. They were all Italians. And Dave said, "They're the happiest people in San Francisco. I'm going to call them for a job." Well it never quite came to that but he did sell sandwiches, going up and down in an elevator in an office building. There were a lot of odd jobs that he did to put food on the table in those days, but it never occurred to either of us he would do anything but be a musician.

MR: Does it make you appreciate the eventual success that much more?

IB: Oh I think so. I think we look back on the times, those early days in San Francisco and

friendships were made during that period when everybody was struggling. And we had a little colony actually in San Francisco, where the rent was cheap in this area, and so we had musicians up and down the block you know.

MR: There was a couple of passages I wanted to ask you about that I read. It must have been very difficult when Dave hurt his back.

IB: Yeah that was a very tough time. That was very, very serious. And it did not only have an impact on our lives at that time, but it had an impact on actually the way he played the piano. Because the injury was such that there were some things that he used to do that he could no longer do. So he had to adjust, and do what he could do. And fortunately I think Dave never prided himself so much on technique as on ideas, and so you found other ways to express those ideas. And then of course the addition of Paul [Desmond] to what had basically been a trio came about because of that injury and when we came back to San Francisco from Hawaii he knew that he could not stay in a club and work all those hours, it would just be impossible with the back injury. And so to add Paul, who had been sitting in and enjoying it and wanting to play, then the burden was divided so that Paul could carry some of the load. But in those days, that back injury was really, really very bad. He would have the lights go out at the end of a set so people couldn't see him and he'd have to pull himself up on the piano because he couldn't just get up. And this was at the Black Hawk. And then go into the back room, where all the liquor was stacked, and that was the dressing room, and actually just lie down on the floor until it was time for the next set. So it was very, very tough. I think it was a big challenge during that period.

MR: And what the medical world could have done for him at that time I'm sure is much different than it is now too.

IB: I'm sorry, I couldn't —

MR: What doctors, the way doctors treat those injuries now probably was in its infancy back then too.

IB: Yeah. Well with the quartet, with the addition of Paul, was the beginning of actual touring outside of San Francisco, Los Angeles, Portland, Salt Lake, that was kind of what they did. And those were tough days too because the pay wasn't that great. Four guys in a station wagon, along with the instruments and, again, it had to be a great commitment on everybody's part. So it really wasn't — see the *Time* magazine cover was in 1954. And one would assume that was sort of, you know, at the height. And actually it wasn't. I mean the pay was still low and the touring was still tough. It was a period where you began to see a brighter future but it wasn't a big payoff.

MR: Well can you recall what the quartet would have got for one average gig? How much money they would have made?

IB: Well this much I can remember. Going to the bank in Oakland when we were proposing to build a house on a lot that had been given to Dave when he got out of the Army. We didn't have the money that we needed in order to get a loan, but we had some contracts for the future. And the contracts for the future for the quartet was $1,000 a night for the quartet, and that was the highest we had ever received at that point. Well realize that out of this $1,000, we pay a commission, transportation to get there, you pay the guys, you pay Social Security, unemployment insurance, liability, and you're not left with that much.

MR: And did he pay the other three guys before he paid himself?

IB: He and Paul had an agreement. The rhythm section would be guaranteed a salary. And the agreement with Paul was — I don't remember the exact amount, whether it was 40 percent or 50 percent or what it was, whatever the gross was, I've forgotten just what the percentage was. So sometimes it ended up that Dave ended up with very little. Because he was paying the transportation, the commissions, and that sort of thing.

MR: Well I've gotten the sense over the years that he has used you as an opinion and a sounding board about some of his work. When I was here ten years ago he was working on a piece. Unfortunately it was the beginning of the Afghanistan war, and he was working on a piece that I believe he said the text encouraged women not have children because the times were so awful. And you told him nobody's going to want to sing that, it's too sad. And it made me think that you're fairly forthright with your opinions about his work.

IB: Well yes. If it's in an area where I think I know something I've always felt that I was sort of like the audience. And if I think there's something that an audience would really love I will tell him that, or if I think it's something they won't — musically I won't step in that area at all. You know I'm not qualified in any way. But going back to the first recordings of the trio, I remember there is a recording on one side, in those days it was 78s so you had two sides. "Body and Soul" with Cal Tjader on bongos. And Dave didn't think that maybe that should go on that side. And I said, "That's the best thing you've done" because I was thinking from an audience standpoint. And sure enough it was something that really went over extremely well. So I guess a sounding board is maybe what you would call it.

MR: Well it's very valuable to have an outside ear I think, because sometimes musicians can't divorce themselves from what they did personally on the performance.

IB: It isn't always an objective opinion perhaps, but at least it's outside the actual creating of the piece itself. And then of course we've worked together on a lot of different projects, and that way we are — I was going to say critical of each other, but we're not critical of

MR: Do the conversations ever get like animated?

IB: Well yeah. Oh yeah. Sometimes if you feel strongly that this word is the correct word, or sometimes I will do something and he'll say, "You know that really doesn't fit with the music." And I take that very seriously then, and try to hear it. So once in a while we have a difference of opinion. Because really our general philosophic views are so similar, that we're not going to fight over ideas you know. It's more how do we best express them.

MR: Well your faith, your religious faith, has come out in a lot of music in the last number of years. And I wondered if that was part of your upbringing, or did you and Dave sort of grow into that together?

IB: The religious faith?

MR: Yes.

IB: More in his upbringing than mine. His mother was very much a *Bible* reader, but more than that, more of a seeker and a searcher. And so he grew up with that background. And his mother was a choir director and as a little kid he went to church that was next door to where he lived in Concord, and on Wednesday nights or whenever the choir practiced he sat there and listened to choir practice. So that was more a part of his life than mine.

MR: When it came time to work on the religious pieces, and you guys worked together with the text from the *Bible* very often.

IB: Yes.

MR: But the first things that you did with him, they were more of a secular nature, like "The Real Ambassadors."

IB: Yes.

MR: When did that come about? Thinking like I can do this with him.

IB: With "The Real Ambassadors?"

MR: Yeah, I guess, but I'm just wondering if there was a point where you said you know what, I think I can make a contribution lyrically?

IB: Well it sort of grew. The idea for "The Real Ambassadors" really came after they did the State Department tour. And I was so impressed with how jazz and music was received in cultures that were different from ours, and what it actually meant at that period in that part of the world. In Poland, for example, jazz just became this symbol of the freedom that they wanted and were seeking. And so it was an underground movement that for some time was forbidden, and by the time, in 1958, when the quartet went there, it had loosened up a little bit so there could be jazz societies. But it was still very suspect. And just from my observations I thought this is something that is not being expressed to the American public as a whole. They knew about the going overseas, the musicians, and as far as the American public is concerned they're just entertaining. But they're not just

how do you express that? How do you get that idea over to the public? Then I decided one way perhaps would be to put it into a musical so that you would have jazz musicians on the stage. I love the sense of humor and I thought if you could just capture some of that, it would be so great, and the public would like it. So that's how it came about, and then getting to Louis Armstrong and talking to him, and much to our surprise he really took it very, very seriously and really wanted to do it. And it's interesting I read a story by Leonard Feather when I was just — fairly recently I read it because I was going through old papers and stuff, where he had interviewed Armstrong in Sweden I think it was, and he was asked what he was interested in doing and he said something about "The Real Ambassadors" and saying that that was something that he hoped he could do because he said it really had meaning for him.

MR: Oh boy that's high praise.

IB: Yeah.

MR: I wonder if I could just play a little bit of this piece.

[audio interlude, "Summer Song" from "The Real Ambassadors"]

It's perfect. I just think it's so — were those your words?

IB: Yes.

MR: They're marvelous, and there is so much symbolism and imagery and the lyric.

IB: Oh well thank you. He loved that song, Louis did. When we had finished recording "The Real Ambassadors" in the 30th Street Studios, he signed "Summer Song" and wrote across it, "Mrs. Brubeck" because he was very formal with me, "Mrs. Brubeck, I am very happy, Satchmo."

MR: That's wonderful. And probably mounting this co-production, trying to get it on Broadway, I can't imagine the hoops that you'd have to.

IB: Well it never came about. Jimmy Lyons at the Monterey Jazz Festival telephoned us. We had moved to Connecticut by that time, and said "I want you do to it in Monterey." Well of course it's not a situation where you can mount a musical in Monterey. And so I decided okay, we'll do it as a concert version with narration of most of the songs. So we had Louis Armstrong and his band, and Paul wasn't in it but Dave and Joe and Eugene. And Lambert, Hendricks and Bavan, Annie had left by that time. And it was a super hit at the Monterey Jazz Festival, and especially among the musicians. I remember Dizzy coming backstage afterwards, really with tears in his eyes. And he said, "I couldn't believe my ears."

MR: Wow. And to put it on in an outdoor venue like that I mean — to go across — that's great.

IB: It's interesting, in more recent times there's been a renewed interest in it. Somebody from

had applied for a grant which he didn't get, but is still holding out hope of maybe doing something. And there've been other people who have shown interest in it, not as a full-blown stage production but maybe a concert production similar to what we had done in Monterey. They are saying enough time has gone by now that it is sort of a reflection of that period in our history.

MR: So you think it could almost stand as it is, as opposed to trying to update it?

IB: I think it's better to be a period piece actually, to reflect the thinking of, well, 1960. The Civil Rights Bill hadn't been signed yet. There was still segregation. We've come a long ways since then.

MR: Well let me rewind just a little bit again. What gave you the idea that jazz concerts, and Dave in particular, might do well in a college setting?

IB: Oh about the college you mean? That was early. And that came about because when he was studying with Milhaud at Mills College, the musicians there all were full of great ideas and performed a concert that was fundraising for scholarships or something, and it was very enthusiastically received by the college population, especially among the music students. So then it seemed the idea was well we'll do the same thing at UC Berkeley. So that was set up. And it became more and more apparent that commercially these same musicians were scrambling, trying to find jobs and playing odd places and doing commercial stuff that they didn't want to do, and the general public not that interested. It was background music in a Chinese restaurant or something. But where the people were really interested and really listening were in the colleges. And so that's when I had the idea, okay, I'll find out the colleges up and down within driving distance of San Francisco, up and down the coast, and write to — usually to the student body — usually there is an arts division where they bring in entertainment. And so we sent out a lot of letters and got a few responses, but it just snowballed from there. And also right in the Bay area Dave had decided early on that the group would play for nothing or next to nothing at any school assembly, any situation where you were meeting young people. And so I think that was the beginning. And then after he had signed with Associated Booking, they took up the idea and they started contacting all of the colleges and first thing you know that became part of a circuit for everybody.

MR: It's almost a period piece in itself with the LPs "Jazz Goes to College." Because now jazz lives in college.

IB: Jazz is in college. That is so true. You know, do you know what year it was that North Texas State started their jazz program?

MR: I think it was in the mid-60s.

IB: It was in the late 40s right?

IB: I think so. I think around '49. Because you know for years they were sort of the farm team for Stan Kenton and Woody Herman.

MR: That's true. You know it took a long time.

IB: And the differences. Because at one time, from the academic standpoint, a conservatory, well at the University of the Pacific, where we went, if you played jazz in the conservatory in the practice room, you could get kicked out. So now it's just an absolute turnaround. And that's something too I think most people forget, that that was part of the whole scene in the 50s and in the 60s of trying to get for jazz the same position in the arts as chamber music or symphonies, or any of the arts. To be recognized as an art. And now it is, and so I think we were our own worst enemy because now it's not part of the general culture that it was in the days of the swing era and the early 50s.

MR: And why is that? I mean you don't see jazz on television.

IB: No.

MR: Unless it's a special event. But that is true. And I guess it's a double-edged sword. Jazz is a highly respected art form.

IB: Yeah. Now it's a respected art so it seems whoever is in charge of things seems to think okay it's not for the general public. And I don't think that's true. I think given an opportunity that the public would go for jazz. If given an opportunity through radio, television, and just part of our everyday commercial life, if it was there I think it would be accepted and enjoyed. It takes perhaps a little more educated ear and that's been one of my hobby horses, education in the schools. Because it has to start from there. And that's why I think you find young people in general, this is a big generality, in Europe accepting jazz as just one more form of music while at the same time they go for the pop stuff and rock and all of that, but they also accept jazz much more I think than in this country, the young people who have not been exposed to jazz and don't really know about it just seem to think it's something that's way over there.

MR: It's curious because we invented jazz in America, right?

IB: Yeah.

MR: And unfortunately sometimes things seem worthwhile if they come from somewhere else. We think they're exotic.

IB: I really don't know just what it is, but in the years that Dave has toured in Europe, just looking at the audience you can see a lot more younger people in the audiences in Europe than you'd see here. Not to say that there aren't some here, but just more young people really interested in jazz. I think it's just part of their culture and part of their education to have some understanding of all the genres of music.

MR: There's many, many young people who love jazz but they want to be the players, right? I

IB: Yes. There are many people who want to play but they need to have an audience and there is the rub.

MR: I want to ask you about, I thought this was just a wonderful little story, that Dave told me that you were driving in a Volkswagen bus up to a camp where your son was and he was trying to finish one of his cantatas, and he said, "Iola I've finished." And you were driving and you said, "No you haven't." He said, "Why?" And you said, "Because you've left out the most important thing about Christmas, and that is God's love made visible." And he said, "I can't fit that in here." And you replied, "Well fine, just see what you can do." I think that's such a great exchange.

IB: Yeah, that's true. And the rest of the way to Vermont we were making up words that would go with that five-four rhythm — I said, "See it's easy." God's love made visible/He is invincible.

MR: What a great little scene, in the back of the van. And then didn't he finish it in the attic or something?

IB: Yeah. And that is the most popular section of that cantata, as a piece by itself, it's sung a lot. In fact it's in some hymn books.

MR: Wow. I'll have to work on that for the Unitarian church that I play at. I'll have to see if I can get that going. Back to paying dues. I don't know if you would remember such an incident but would you remember the first time a check came to your house for one of Dave's compositions? Like an ASCAP royalty or BMI or something like that?

IB: No I don't remember the first. Let me see. I remember a couple of things. I remember when Dave signed with Columbia he received an advance and of course there was royalties against the advance and I can remember being quite excited and surprised to see how fast he was able to reach that point to actually be receiving royalties, because he'd paid off the advance and was receiving royalties. Because "Jazz Goes to College" sold very well. And I remember George Avakian was surprised and we were all surprised that it sold as well as it did. That I remember.

MR: And he would get slightly more money if he had his own compositions on the records too, wouldn't he?

IB: I'm sorry, I didn't hear.

MR: Well writer's royalty? If he had his own tunes on the records as opposed to standards, did he get a little bit more?

IB: Well that has a little history too. First he recorded all standards, and then at Columbia there were a few originals and they said, "Okay we'll put them in our publishing company." And we weren't smart enough to know that you didn't have to do that. And it wasn't until we had some business management that said, "You know you can have your

own publishing company." We thought aha, this is a revelation. So that made a very big difference.

MR: I'm glad you found that out when you did.

IB: I'm glad we found it out before "Time Out."

MR: Well again, you said how you and George Avakian were surprised at the success of "Jazz Goes to College." Were you surprised at the success of "Time Out?"

IB: Of "Time Out?" Well yes. There was no anticipation that it was going to be a hit of any kind. And in fact, you know, it's an old story now that Dave has often told of having to fight at Columbia to even have it released and Goddard Lieberson liked the concept and he said he thought he could sell it to the people on the west coast maybe, and he took "Take Five" and went out to sales meeting on the west coast, saying this is something new and I think we can really push this, and the sales people saying, "No way." So it really was a result of — God bless 'em — disc jockeys who were looking for something different to play and saying well this sounds interesting and then putting it on and then it got a public reaction, and then it started taking off. So it was really the public deciding that this is what they wanted to hear.

MR: I can testify to that. As a junior high kid I heard that on the radio and it made me sit up and I had to go what it that, and I immediately went and bought the record.

IB: Uh huh. We get letters like that quite often, people saying, "I thought what is that?" and then following their interest. Again it broke the mold and that's always a little challenging to a lot of people who don't know how to handle it. And of course by this time it's notorious in jazz history lore is that terrible review that *Down Beat* gave "Time Out." I think it got a star and a half or something.

MR: And just recently of course "Blue Rondo" is included on the Smithsonian's Jazz CD collection. They chose that particular tune too.

IB: Right. That again was one of those things. I was glad that we lived long enough to see that omission of Dave from the Smithsonian Jazz Anthology — it was incredible. And when that happened I said well, okay, they have to cover so many years, maybe that's forgivable. Then came the Jazz Piano Anthology. He wasn't in that one. Wait a minute. That isn't even accurate history. Whether you like that style of piano or not, if you're going to compile something that is supposed to be jazz history that just is not right.

MR: Do you think there's any political correctness that still goes on in the business between black musicians and white musicians?

IB: I think there was a time when that was an issue for some people. I see less and less of it. And you know among the people who were really firmly established, Duke for example, he never saw any of that. And I think for most musicians, can you play? And are you a

to Dave. And before Dave was known, Duke came into a club in San Francisco and talked to him, and said, "You know you should go to New York. If you're really going to make it you have to go to New York. And I can get you into the Hickory House." So that showed, in Duke's mind, I'm sure that didn't enter into it.

MR: He was a classy man.

IB: Yeah.

MR: And your children gravitated. The cellist, is Michael?

IB: Matthew.

MR: Matthew said when asked about making a living as a musician he said, "I didn't know there was any other way."

IB: I know. I think that's the way all of them felt, that music was just around them all the time when they were growing up, and I know I've heard our oldest one, Darius, explain, it just seemed like the grown-ups were having so much fun and they were just playing and it just seemed like something that, "That's what I want to do when I grow up." And they all started taking lessons when they were pretty young and they drifted from one instrument to another and finally settled on what they wanted to play. And they're all good musicians.

MR: Did they have a sense early on that their — I'm not sure how to ask this — that their father was a well-known public figure? Did they understand that?

IB: I think that that is when you are an adolescent and in your early years I think that is an issue that you have to adjust to, and again, our oldest son has talked about it more I think than most of the others, and he probably felt it more than the others, because he was an adolescent just at the time that Dave's fame was at its greatest. And he was saying that it took him a while to realize while I'm not my father, that there is no reason for me to be comparing myself with my father. I have my own positives and negatives, and he has, but he said it took a while for him. Because also he's the pianist of the group and I think that made it doubly difficult.

MR: And you weren't really able to travel too much with Dave until the children got to be a certain age?

IB: Yeah. Quite a bit older. Matthew, the youngest, went to boarding school at Choate so he was at that point I guess 14 or something like that. And after that I started, not all the time, but then in more recent years I've traveled with him all the time.

MR: I know travel was difficult for him, and I wondered, do you like it?

IB: It depends on where we're going and how we get there. It's difficult. I would say it's no longer fun to get on an airplane and travel. And for a while Dave was saying, "Well we'll just do stuff that we can drive to." And that's more or less what we've done more

recently. But I would say the excitement of leaving here and going someplace else is not what it used to be. I think we're pretty happy just to be here.

MR: Yeah, it's a beautiful spot.

IB: It's a good place to be.

MR: I want to thank you for your effort you put into the newsletter for those years.

IB: Oh thank you. I sort of hated to give it up but it does take a lot of time and energy and there's so much else going on and I'm trying to work with Dave to write an autobiography and if I'm going to do that I can't spend the time with the newsletter. Although I found the newsletter helpful in trying to go back and remember certain events.

MR: Would you have him sit and just talk?

IB: What is it?

MR: Would you have him sit and just talk about his life?

IB: Yes. And sometimes, you know, the years when I was not traveling with him I'll ask him a lot of questions and see what he can remember. I think after a while, and it's true with me too, that everything kind of comes into one. You can't remember specific events that well. And also it's true about memory, if it's a story that you've never told it probably won't come up when you're trying to think about it. That's the way the mind works.

MR: Yes. And sometimes we tend to not want to keep the bad parts in the forefront.

IB: Exactly. Push those over to the side.

MR: I know one question I've tried a number of times and it hardly ever works is like what was your worst gig? And people tend not to — they'd have to really think about it.

IB: Well there have been a few that stand out.

MR: Well would the question work for you?

IB: Well one that I can think of, it wasn't that long ago, maybe in the 80s, and we were in Europe, and for some unknown reason the quartet was booked I guess it would be like in a folkpark or something, in, I think it was Sweden. And so we had a long drive from Stockholm to get to this place, and when we got there the venue was, it would be like maybe a rec room or something like that. It was just a low ceiling room. Nothing was set up. There were no speakers, no microphones, no nothing. And as it turned out, when it came time to perform, there were no people. I mean there was a handful of people there. And you go to all this effort.

MR: You don't expect that for the Dave Brubeck Quartet.

IB: You just wonder why? Why? It didn't make any sense at all. And then Dave tells about flying his group and Mingus' group, flying to someplace in the North Pole as far as he's concerned, in Finland, and a similar thing. When they got there they found the venue they were to play, it was in a classroom. And again, a handful of people. Why they were sent

there is beyond — a complete mystery. And no place for them to stay. So after they play, then they get back on a plane and fly back to Helsinki or someplace.

MR: I don't know if you can answer this question, but you and Dave seem like such peaceful people. And I wonder what makes you angry?

IB: What makes me angry?

MR: What makes you angry? Is there anything?

IB: Yeah. Injustice. That is something. It's not a just world. You have to accept that fact, but I hate to see anyone treated badly, not even the right to be themselves, and the stereotyping of people, that's an injustice, by the color of the skin or the way they look or the way they walk or the way they're dressed or whatever. That I really can't tolerate. That's where I'm intolerant.

MR: Are you an optimist though? Is Dave an optimist?

IB: Oh yeah. Why not? The alternative is to be unhappy and not enjoy the day as it is. I think you know, at this point in our lives we have to accept each day as a gift and I think that being pessimistic and all that angst that one goes through sometimes in younger people, it's okay. I mean that's part of growing up and coming through it. I think we've all had those periods. But generally speaking Dave and I both, even at the worst times, have felt well we'll get through this.

MR: Part of paying dues I guess. And the Institute, which is ten years old now?

IB: Yes. And I'm so pleased with what it has done. It has really given these young people who have been fellows there really a start that we just wish that all students that are really talented could have. Because it gives them, right out of high school, one or two years in a protected environment where they just concentrate on being good musicians. And in the process of doing that there are a lot of performances. And in these performances some of them are outreaches where they go into the schools and capture the imagination of younger people thinking well here are these kids and not too much older than they are, wow. They can do that, maybe I can do that. So it generates an interest. And I mean they've done well, the kids that have come out of there. Most of them have gone to Juilliard or Manhattan School of Music or the New School. And every once in a while when we're on the road we run into one of them, saying well, "I'm on my way to Australia," or, "I'm on my way to Japan," and it makes you feel really good.

MR: One of them was from near us, from Syracuse I believe, Nick Frenay I think his name was, a trumpet player. That's really neat, because it's like almost the way young jazz musicians learned to operate in the world. They would be playing at a young age with mentors.

IB: That's right. And it's the opportunity that isn't given to them so much now. So the

you just played and you hung out with other musicians, you learned from each other, and that opportunity isn't there now. There aren't the venues and the opportunity to do that. And the old way had its hazards also, and that's why — from booze to dope to whatever, and that's why as I said it's a protected environment. You have the artistic director, Joe Gilman is for the kids, the executive director, there's always somebody there. And if somebody breaks any of the rules they're out and out fast.

MR: Like a tough band leader.

IB: Yeah. And when you speak to some of the kids who have gone through that program, one of the answers that I heard that I really like, was he said, "You know I didn't feel like I was in a jazz studies program. I felt that I was being my own person was being addressed and developed." And he said, "We learned from each other and we learned how to be a leader" because they rotate on who is going to be the leader of the group. We learned how to compromise, we learned how to respect people with different approaches to music, and by having this little micro cosmos of five kids, all very talented who respect each other, they learn a lot. It's a crucible for a year or two.

MR: That's great. I think one of the highest compliments that can be paid to songwriters is when other people perform their music. So I just wanted to play. I'm hoping you've heard this.

[audio interlude "Summer Song/Summertime"]

Have you heard this?

IB: I hadn't heard it.

MR: Well I'm going to send you a copy of it. It's just the most beautiful thing. Almost as beautiful as Louis singing it. That's Jackie & Roy.

IB: Oh that's beautiful.

MR: And I'm very appreciative of your spending your time with me today.

IB: Well I hope that it's helpful. You evidently have a very good archive going, huh?

MR: We do. We've done 300+ interviews and we have a nice on-line presence now and it's been a dream gig for me to meet all my musical heroes.

IB: It's interesting too, and I should have brought it up when we were talking about where did you get the idea for "The Real Ambassadors," because Joe Williams was a part of that. That summer I was in New York and I went to Central Park and Joe Williams was with the Basie band, and he was just so great. And the night before I had gone to a Broadway musical. And I said to myself Joe Williams said more and reached more emotionally with the Basie band that night than that big production I'd seen the night before. And that was one of the reasons why I started thinking in terms of a Broadway show.

IB: That's what I understand. Well I loved Joe Williams. He was a wonderful, wonderful man. He was another example of a black man who, right at the height of the sort of division that was going on in jazz was not affected by that. And I can remember in Europe one time, Joe and some other musicians were sitting outside a hotel in the summertime, on a sort of patio, and our car pulled up and Dave and I got out of the van and Joe got up from where he was sitting with the other musicians and came over and they embraced, he gave Dave a hug and so forth. And it was just kind of a way of him saying, "Cool it guys."

MR: Another great story.

IB: A lot of humanity.

MR: Yeah. Well on that note, thank you again.

IB: You're very, very welcome.